COMSATS University Islamabad (CUI)

Park Road, Tarlai Kalan, Islamabad-45550

Department of Biosciences

Monday, 23 January 2026

To the Alumni Excellence Awards Selection Committee,

I am pleased to write this letter in strong support of Dr. Saima for the Alumni Excellence Award. I supervised Dr. Saima during her Doctor of Philosophy in Molecular Genetics at COMSATS University Islamabad, and I can state with confidence that she is among the most dedicated, intellectually driven, and ethically grounded researchers I have mentored.

Dr. Saima's doctoral thesis, *"Genetic Analysis of Ciliopathies Disease Spectrum,"* addressed complex and underexplored genetic disorders using advanced molecular and genomic approaches. She demonstrated exceptional skill in whole-exome sequencing, variant prioritization, and genotype–phenotype correlation, particularly within consanguineous populations. Her work contributed novel insights to rare disease genetics and resulted in multiple peer-reviewed publications in reputable international journals.

What impressed me most during her PhD was her independence as a scientist. Dr. Saima required minimal supervision, consistently proposed innovative experimental strategies, and showed remarkable perseverance when addressing technically challenging problems. She completed her degree with a CGPA of 3.65/4.0, reflecting sustained academic excellence throughout her doctoral training.

In addition to her research accomplishments, Dr. Saima was deeply engaged in mentorship and laboratory development. She supervised Master's and undergraduate students, established new laboratory protocols, maintained laboratory organization, and contributed to standard operating procedures that strengthened our research infrastructure. Her ability to mentor junior trainees with patience and clarity speaks to her leadership potential and commitment to academic service.

Dr. Saima's excellence has been consistently recognized through competitive awards and fellowships, including the International Research Fellowship from the Higher Education Commission of Pakistan and the Indigenous Scholarship leading to PhD. These honors reflect both her merit and her determination to pursue scientific excellence despite structural and resource challenges.

Her continued academic success including advanced graduate training and postdoctoral research at the University of Alberta is a natural extension of the qualities she demonstrated during her PhD. Dr. Saima represents the very best of alumni who combine scholarly rigor with social responsibility and global impact.

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I offer my strongest endorsement of Dr. Saima for the Alumni Excellence Award and am confident she will continue to make meaningful contributions to science, medicine, and mentorship.

Sincerely,

Dr. Maleeha Azam
Associate Professor

Department of Biosciences
COMSATS University Islamabad, Pakistan